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State pushes 'first in the nation' grocery label for highlighting non-ultra-processed foods

March 28, 2026 | Africa Newswire (Africa)
Section: News | 461 Words
OpenURL Link

28 Mar 2026 (TourismAfrica2006) California consumers may soon see a new label on grocery shelves - one designed to highlight foods that are not ultra-processed.

Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel introduced the bill behind the proposal on Wednesday, according to a press release shared with Fox News Digital.

The legislation, AB 2244, would establish a "California Certified" seal that manufacturers could place on products that meet standards for not being ultra-processed foods (UPFs).

The legislation would also require grocery stores to prominently display products bearing the seal in high-traffic areas, making it easier for consumers to find those items.

Gabriel's office described the seal as a "first-in-the-nation" label.

Not only would the seal allow shoppers to make more informed decisions, but it may also put some pressure on manufacturers to reformulate their products to qualify.

The bill defines ultra-processed foods as those containing certain additives, such as emulsifiers and preservatives, along with high levels of sugar, salt or fat.

"Parents shouldn't need a Ph.D. in chemistry to understand what they're feeding their kids," Gabriel said in the release.

"While Washington, D.C., is paralyzed by inaction, California is stepping up to protect our kids and confront the health risks associated with ultra-processed foods."

Gabriel said he hopes to have the bill on Gov. Gavin Newsom's desk by late summer, according to STAT News.

Speaking to Fox News Digital, Gabriel said the bill "provides a market-based solution to address the dangers of ultra-processed foods."

He added, "[It] strengthens consumer choice, drives innovation and promotes healthier options across the food supply - without banning any products."

Gabriel told Politico the bill is the "next logical step" in addressing ultra-processed foods in grocery stores.

"But we're doing it in a way that strengthens consumer choice and encourages innovation," he added.

Though the definition of UPFs is debated, they're generally understood to be foods that undergo multiple industrial processes.

These processes make them "stabilized for consumption," Dr. Jeffrey Kraft, a bariatric surgeon at Hackensack Meridian Palisades Medical Center in New Jersey, previously told Fox News Digital.

"Processed foods are not natural foods," he said. "They've gone through a factory or been chemically changed so they last longer on the shelf."

Kraft added, "They are almost always combined with other unhealthy things, like high fructose corn syrup, emulsifiers and hydrogenated oils."

The lack of a "clear universal standard" for what a UPF is "opens the door for bureaucrats to decide what's real," said California-based chef Andrew Gruel.

"I am all for transparency, and encourage it, but that should come from clear and honest ingredient labeling, not some pay-to-play subjective stamp that reduces foods into a government label," Gruel told Fox News Digital.

He added, "I am confident this label will get hijacked by the large food manufacturers and Doritos will be considered a non-processed food by some weird definition, just like chips used to be labeled heart healthy."

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  State pushes 'first in the nation' grocery label for highlighting non-ultra-processed foods. (2026, March 28).*Africa Newswire (Africa)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A72569EC23CFB98.